

An **essay** is, generally, a piece of writing that gives the author's own **argument**, but the definition is vague, overlapping with those of a **letter**, a **paper**, an **article**, a **pamphlet**, and a **short story**. Essays have been sub-classified as formal and informal: formal essays are characterized by "serious purpose, dignity, logical organization, length," whereas the informal essay is characterized by "the personal element (self-revelation, individual tastes and experiences, confidential manner), humor, graceful style, rambling structure, unconventionality or novelty of theme," etc.^[1]

Essays are commonly used as **literary criticism**, political **manifestos**, learned **arguments**, observations of daily life, recollections, and reflections of the author. Almost all modern essays are written in **prose**, but works in **verse** have been dubbed essays (e.g., **Alexander Pope's** *An Essay on Criticism* and *An Essay on Man*). While brevity usually defines an essay, voluminous works like **John Locke's** *An Essay Concerning Human Understanding* and **Thomas Malthus's** *An Essay on the Principle of Population* are counterexamples.

In some countries (e.g., the United States and Canada), essays have become a major part of formal **education**.^[2] Secondary students are taught structured essay formats to improve their writing skills; **admission essays** are often used by **universities** in selecting applicants, and in the humanities and social sciences essays are often used as a way of assessing the performance of students during final exams.

The concept of an "essay" has been extended to other media beyond writing. A **film essay** is a movie that often incorporates documentary filmmaking styles and focuses more on the evolution of a theme or idea. A **photographic essay** covers a topic with a linked series of **photographs** that may have accompanying text or **captions**.